inevitably, working (a courier delivered mail from Berlin daily). Like many East Germans of his generation, he could not imagine a holiday without getting a suntan and bathing in the Baltic. Moreover, the breaks gave Margot the chance to energetically ‘play house’ and fuss over Sonja. Margot was also passionate about skiing and often took holidays at the snow-covered Erzgebirge Forest between Fichtelberg and Tellerhäuser on the Czech border, where she was occasionally accompanied by Eberhard Riedel, the GDR’s most famous alpine skier, known for his appearance at the 1960 Winter Olympics.

By this point, Margot (with eight years of elementary school on her CV) had risen to the post of Deputy Minister of Education and was involved in the socialist development of the school system. A snide joke overheard at the time asked: ‘Why are the foundations of the new Ministry of Education building being dug so deep?’ –The punchline: ‘They are looking for the diplomas of the Comrade Deputy Minister!’

Under her watch, the curriculum was centralised, ideologically charged and obligatory. She backed a law for the introduction of polytechnic schooling, designed to further develop technical and intellectual leadership skills, increased vocational training opportunities and helped expand public childcare facilities, increasing crèche places. In March 1960, she announced a seven-year scheme to build 700 new schools, saying ‘the fulfilment of the building plan was the most important task of the moment. It must be our goal to make this a matter for the whole population’. Her appointments calendar for the next decade shows ministerial duties took her to Rome, Paris, Havana, Moscow, Helsinki and countless other destinations. In July 1960, she led the first sizeable educational delegation from the GDR to China for a month-long visit to inspect colleges, universities, vocational schools, as well as secondary and elementary schools. ‘Our delegation has set itself the task of rendering the cooperation between our two countries closer within the framework of the agreement on culture,’ she told ADN’s correspondent in Beijing. ‘We have found much we have in common, since in China, too, on the basis of Marxism-Leninism, school is linked with life and tuition with production.’9